EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

One God or Two?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 2:1-3

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 2 (the Unity of the Creator), Chapters 1 to 3 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 10 June 2024, on Zoom (the night before Erev Shavuot)

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where We Are

We have studied the eight chapters of the **Introduction** in detail, then spent several weeks on **Essay 1**, all about the creation of the universe. We are now in **Essay 2**, on **Yichud Hashem**, the unity of HaKadosh Baruch Hu.

Last week's introduction to the essay made one main point: **the more subtle an argument, the more theoretical and abstract it becomes.** Rav Saadia warned us not to expect something concrete at the end of an investigation into the unity of Hashem. "This is definitely a sound logical argument nowadays as well. The deeper you go into something, the more abstract it becomes."

The plan for tonight was three short chapters:

Chapter	Subject
1	The five things the prophets tell us about Hashem, and three rational proofs that He is one
2	Refuting the **dualists**, who say there are two gods
3	Verses that seem to imply more than one deity, such as **Hashem Elohim**

Chapter 1: Five Things the Prophets Tell Us

Rav Saadia begins: HaKadosh Baruch Hu has told us through the prophets that He is:

#	Attribute	Verses brought
1	**One**	**שמע ישראל ה׳ אלהינו ה׳ אחד** (Devarim 6:4), and **ראו עתה כי אני אני הוא ואין אלהים עמדי**, "See now that I, I am He, and there is no god with Me"
2	**Living**: He is involved in the universe	"Who of all flesh has heard the voice of the living God speaking?" There is revelation and interaction. And Yirmiyahu: Hashem is the living God
3	**Omnipotent**	**ידעת כי כל תוכל ולא יבצר ממך מזמה**, I know that You can do all, and nothing is withheld from You" (Iyov 42:2), and Divrei HaYamim: everything is Yours, Hashem
4	**Omniscient**	A verse in Iyov: we cannot even fathom the depths of God's wisdom
5	**Incomparable**	Tehillim: there is none like Him

"We have all the miracles in the Torah to verify this," but Rav Saadia does exactly what he promised in the Introduction: first he brings the verses, and then he shows that philosophical analysis reaches the same conclusion. The **thirteen chapters of Essay 2** will discuss each of these five. The first three chapters deal only with the first: **unity**.

A word on "attributes"

The Rabbi was careful about the word:

"I'm careful to use the word *attributes*, because like we will discuss, there is no way to give attributes. Part of God's simplicity is that there is no division. There are no parts to Him."

When we speak about the **thirteen attributes of mercy**, or these five attributes in Rav Saadia, we do not mean HaKadosh Baruch Hu has different parts. As the Rambam teaches, the attributes describe **how He relates to us as humans** and how He is revealed to us, not what He actually is. "We have to be always careful and have that in mind."

The two roots of error

Rav Saadia says that those who deny the unity of God fall into one of two mistakes:

1. **They compare God to His creatures,** to everything else that exists, and do not see that He is entirely different.
2. **They seize on every word.** The Rabbi loved Rav Saadia's phrase here: such a person "catches us with every word" the Torah uses to describe God, reading each one physically and literally, not as metaphor.

Rav Saadia will discuss later in the book when the Torah may be read metaphorically. The Rabbi mentioned he had given a shiur on this about a year earlier, based on Rav Saadia and the Rambam's approach in the Moreh Nevuchim.

Three Proofs That Hashem Is One

Proof 1: Number belongs to matter

In Essay 1, one of the arguments for a Creator was that there must be something **distinct and different** from everything else in existence. An essential feature of physical things is that they

have **number and quantity**.

So if we say there is more than one deity, we have given the Creator quantity, and He enters the ordinary laws of physical beings. This principle comes from **Aristotle**, and the Rambam also discusses it in the **Moreh Nevuchim**: anything that is many, anything with quantity, is matter. The essence of something that is not matter is that it has no quantity.

"Now, I don't think it's compelling, this," the Rabbi said, "but this was an old argument."

Proof 2: There is no need for a second

All the proofs in Essay 1 established **a** Creator. Once we have established one, why posit a second? Nothing in those proofs calls for it.

Proof 3: There is no proof of a second

The third is related but goes further. Logically, I have only brought proof of one Creator. How can I then leap to a second? (Someone might say there *is* a reason to posit a second. That is what Chapter 2 deals with.)

"Three arguments, not extremely strong"

The Rabbi's assessment: "Three arguments, not extremely strong, but rational, logical arguments." He added that today people struggle to believe in **one** God. The struggle is no longer two gods against one. But in Rav Saadia's day there were people who believed exactly that, the dualist **Manichaean** system from Iran that the class met in Essay 1, so he now turns to refute them.

(He also noted that the Sefaria English translation stops here, "so maybe someone can take the initiative of writing the translation. All of Sefaria is only people writing translations, so everyone needs to contribute.")

Chapter 2: Against the Dualists

Rav Saadia says that any argument he uses to disprove dualism is also a proof for monotheism. He touched on this in Essay 1, but now he adds more.

Argument 1: Why stop at two?

I ask the dualists: if you want more than one deity, why only two? Why not three, or four? Why not say everything in existence has its own god? Once you posit two, where is the limit?

They answer: the many different circumstances of life can all be put into **two categories**. Everything is either beneficial or harmful, useful or destructive. So there are two deities: a god of light, of benefit and of doing good to humanity, and a god of darkness, destruction and evil.

Rabbi Sacks on why dualism appeals

The Rabbi brought a point he attributed to Rabbi Sacks's book *Morality*: people like dualism because it gives an easy way to understand the world. If you like things binary and black and white, with no grey, it fits perfectly: the god of the good and the god of the bad. Monotheism is harder to live with. We believe in One, yet we see darkness, problems and suffering, "and that's sometimes too difficult for people to accept. So what's easier is, let's make two gods."

Rav Saadia's reply: there are many other ways to divide the world

Even if you divide things into beneficial and harmful, why stop there? Rav Saadia lists other natural divisions, any of which could just as well give you a pantheon:

Category	How many
The senses (each beneficial or harmful)	5, so 5 × 2 = 10
Natural colours	7
Tastes	9
Elements	4
Categories of substance	10
Kinds of motion	6
Kinds of quantity	7
Tenses: past, present, future	3

On the nine tastes, the Rabbi read Rav Saadia's grouping: sweet and fatty, which are moist and hot; bitter, salty and sharp, which are hot and dry; astringent, sour and pungent, which are dry and cold; and the tasteless, like water. "I don't know the details of what these nine are, but apparently they're nine." "Remember I told you right at the beginning, he loves numbers. He loves categorising, quantifying." (In those days, he noted, they had no periodic table and spoke of four elements.)

The dualists, says Rav Saadia, simply picked one number out of all the possible numbers.

The Rabbi's difficulty with this argument

The Rabbi was candid:

"I don't really find this argument very strong at all, actually. I'm positing two because I see good and bad in the world. There's no need to go more than what I have to. Once you're going up, you go up as much as you need to in your philosophy."

A dualist who cannot accept good and bad from one deity goes to two, and two suffices. "I find the whole thrust of his argument quite difficult, unless anyone's got another way of understanding it."

A participant suggested Rav Saadia means **subcategories** of gods: within "bad" you could have war, pestilence and so on, each with its own deity. And **Mark** added that what one person finds useful another finds useless, so you would have to keep subdividing. "In a sense people pick their deities." The Rabbi agreed: "The pagans had all kinds of gods. Once you go into two, you can end up anywhere. I suppose that's what he's saying."

Argument 2: How would two gods work together?

The second argument is more philosophical, and the Rabbi called it strong. Suppose there are two deities and something is to be created:

Option	Problem
They can only create **together**	Then each one is incomplete. That is not the God we have described
Each **forces** the other (light forces darkness to create good, and vice versa)	Then neither is free or complete
Each does **what it chooses**	Then there would be constant conflict. The god of death says kill and the god of life says live, so things would be living and dying at the same moment, and everything would be a permanent mixture of light and darkness

"How are you going to understand this combination of the two deities? It's illogical, it doesn't make sense, and I think we can agree that's a strong argument."

Rav Saadia anticipates further replies: perhaps one hides from the other when it gives life. Then it is not all-knowing. Perhaps there is a link between them. Then it is really one big God, or there must be a third thing between them.

"Take it to heart"

Having disproved more than one deity, we can accept what the Tanach tells us:

> You have been shown to know that Hashem is **אתה הראת לדעת כי ה׳ הוא האלהים אין עוד מלבדו** God; there is none besides Him. (Devarim 4:35)
>
> And you shall know this day and take it to your heart. (Devarim 4:39) **וידעת היום והשבת אל לבבך**

The Rabbi dwelt on this. Yichud Hashem is not something you know once and are done with. It is so easy to see the darkness and suffering in the world and say there must be other powers. And when we do not recognise that everything that happens to us is from HaKadosh Baruch Hu, that too is a denial of Yichud Hashem.

"It's something which we need to constantly work on, which is why morning and evening we remind ourselves God is one. Not just one God and not two deities, but there's nothing else: no other forces, no other powers. You begin your day, everything from Hashem. You come home in the evening, everything from Hashem. You put your tefillin on, it's all about Yichud Hashem. That's what life is all about."

He added that the **Ramchal** held that the whole of creation is about the **revelation of Hashem's oneness**.

Summary of Chapter 2

1. **Why stop at two?** You could divide the world into any number of categories.
2. **How would two gods combine?** They would be in constant conflict, things would live and die at once, and the world would be a far bigger mess than it is.

In Essay 1 Rav Saadia showed that two gods could not have created the world. Now he shows that two gods existing at all makes no sense.

Chapter 3: Hashem and Elohim

What Rav Saadia does *not* say

Before the chapter, the Rabbi asked the class: why does the Torah sometimes use the four-letter name and sometimes **Elohim**? Everyone knows the answer: **Elohim is midat hadin**, the attribute of justice, and **Hashem is midat harachamim**, the attribute of mercy.

"That's a beautiful answer. But Saadia doesn't go on to that. Saadia doesn't say that at all in this chapter, which is fascinating." Rav Saadia had no Kabbalah in the form we know it today: no Zohar, no Arizal. Things we grow up hearing as children, he does not mention, whether because he did not know them or did not accept them.

Flora objected that he must have known something, because the dualists were pointing to these very names. The Rabbi agreed that this is the question Rav Saadia is addressing.

The documentary hypothesis

Because Flora raised it, the Rabbi mentioned it briefly, though "I don't like to create doubts in people's minds." The **documentary hypothesis** arose in Germany in the last couple of hundred years: the claim that the Torah is an amalgamation of **four texts**. It has since been debunked, he said, though other hypotheses have replaced it. One of its strongest arguments is that **Bereishit chapter 1 uses only Elohim**, while chapter 2 introduces the four-letter name (**ה׳ אלהים**). Supposedly these are two texts about two gods, later stitched together.

Rabbi Soloveitchik in *The Lonely Man of Faith* "really rips it apart" and explains the beauty of why there are two accounts. "It's a worthwhile read. It's a very hard read," because his English is so high-level.

Rav Saadia is responding to a version of this question a thousand years earlier. He is not dealing with two authors, but with the claim that the two names mean two gods.

Question 1: Why do the names change?

Rav Saadia answers simply. If the Tanach used Hashem in some places and Elohim in others with no further information, you would have an argument for two deities. But Scripture **explicitly tells us they are the same**:

> For thus says Hashem, Creator of the heavens: He is God. **כי כה אמר ה׳ בורא השמים הוא האלהים** (Yeshayahu 45:18)

> Know that Hashem is God. (Tehillim 100:3) **דעו כי ה׳ הוא אלהים**

And when all the people cried out at the altar, **ה׳ הוא האלהים**, "Hashem is God," as we cry out in Selichot and on Yom Kippur. Once this is established, it should not bother us which name is used where.

Gideon and Yerubaal

Rav Saadia's example is two consecutive verses in Shoftim (8:29-30):

> Yerubaal son of Yoash went and dwelt in his **וילך ירבעל בן יואש וישב בביתו. ולגדעון היו שבעים בנים** house. And Gideon had seventy sons.

Are there two people, one called Gideon and one called Yerubaal? No. The context shows they are the same person, the judge Gideon son of Yoash. Once we know that, it does not bother us

when the text switches names. In the same way, once the Tanach has told us that Hashem is Elohim, the change of names is no problem.

Rav Saadia does not explain *why* the Torah uses one name or the other, the Rabbi told Flora. "It could well be that he accepted that" (*midat hadin* and so on), "it could well be that he's just not going into that now." His point is only that once we know it is the same God, it makes no difference.

Question 2: "Hashem *and* God"

The harder case is where a verse joins two names with a **vav**, "and", which seems to imply two:

אלהי ואדני לריבי My God and my Lord, for my cause. (Tehillim 35:23)

וירעם מן שמים ה׳ ועליון יתן קולו Hashem thundered from heaven, and the Most High gave forth His voice. (Shmuel II 22:14)

Who is Hashem and who is the Most High? Here the same speaker seems to name two gods.

The answer, "really not difficult": the vav here means **"as well"**, adding a second reason or description. Who thunders from heaven? The One who is both Hashem and the Most High, because He is supreme and because He is Hashem. Rav Saadia proves it from:

שמעו זאת כל העמים האזינו כל ישבי חלד, גם בני אדם גם בני איש Hear this, all you peoples; listen, all inhabitants of the world, both sons of *adam* and sons of *ish*. (Tehillim 49:2-3)

Are "nations" and "inhabitants of the world" two categories of people, or *adam* and *ish* two kinds of human? Clearly not. It is one audience, described several ways for emphasis. Likewise **יעקב עבדי וישרון בחרתי בו**, "Yaakov My servant, and Yeshurun whom I have chosen" (Yeshayahu 44:2): Yaakov and Yeshurun are the same person.

A key principle: when to read the Torah as metaphor

Here Rav Saadia states, almost in passing, a principle the Rabbi said is important to remember:

Wherever we, the believers in One God, find any text about God's actions or His creation that **contradicts sound logic and proper analysis**, we must say that **the language is not to be taken literally.**

"Nowadays we accept this. We know that many things are metaphorical. But in Saadia's time this was quite radical," because many believed the Torah must be read literally. He is willing to say: wherever something about God contradicts sound logic, do not be afraid to read it metaphorically.

The Rabbi connected this to the **Rambam in the Moreh Nevuchim**, from an earlier shiur on Aristotle. The Rambam famously wrote that if Aristotle could prove the universe is eternal, he would reinterpret **בראשית ברא אלהים**. He even wrote that this would be **easier** for him than reinterpreting all the verses that seem to give Hashem a body: Hashem's hand, Hashem's arm. "So Saadia is already preceding him by 200 years."

Rav Saadia says he will not explain here *how* to interpret metaphorically, since he covered that in his introduction to the Torah. But later in this book he will discuss *when* a person has licence to do so.

Question 3: "Hashem sent me, and His spirit"

The third question, "relatively the biggest," is:

ועתה ה׳ אלהים שלחני ורוחו (Yeshayahu 48:16) And now Hashem God has sent me, and His spirit.

This, the Rabbi noted, was a famous verse used by **Christians** to prove the Trinity. Read simply, there is God and there is His spirit, two distinct things: "at least one and a half."

Rav Saadia answers that for this to make sense it must mean **ברוחו**, "**with** His spirit." He brings parallels:

דרשו ה׳ ועזו, "Seek Hashem and His strength" (Tehillim 105:4), "which we say every day," means "seek Hashem **in** His might, not Hashem plus His might.

ועליך יזרח ה׳ וכבודו עליך יראה, "Upon you Hashem will shine, and His glory will appear upon you" (Yeshayahu 60:2), does not mean two things. Hashem is revealed **with** His glory.

"You have to be willing to metaphorise it when necessary."

Summary

1. **Chapter 1:** the prophets tell us Hashem is **one, living, omnipotent, omniscient and incomparable**. Essay 2 will cover all five. The "attributes" describe how Hashem relates to us, not parts of Him.
2. People deny unity either by **comparing God to creatures** or by **reading every word literally**.
3. **Three proofs of unity:** number belongs to matter; there is no need for a second Creator; there is no proof of one. "Not extremely strong, but rational."
4. **Chapter 2, against dualism:** why stop at two, when the world divides into five senses, seven colours, nine tastes? (The Rabbi found this weak.) And how would two gods cooperate? They would be in constant conflict. (The Rabbi found this strong.)
5. **"Take it to heart":** Yichud Hashem must be worked on daily, recognising that everything comes from Hashem.
6. **Chapter 3:** Hashem and Elohim are the same, as Scripture says explicitly, just as **Gideon is Yerubaal**. The vav in "Hashem and the Most High" means "as well". "Hashem sent me **and** His spirit" means **with** His spirit.
7. **The principle:** anything about God that contradicts sound reason must be read as metaphor, two centuries before the Rambam said the same.

Much of this is basic and accepted today, the Rabbi said, "but it's nice to see them in their original form, how these arguments were first articulated." Rav Saadia was writing against all the sects around him, and he goes to painstaking lengths even on things we now take for granted. Essay 3 will bring more *chiddush*.

Coming Up

- **Next Monday:** Chapters 4 and 5 of Essay 2: the other attributes of Hashem, that He is living and omnipotent, philosophically and from the verses.
- **Shavuot:** a participant mentioned the custom of staying awake on the night of 4 Sivan, citing the Zohar on Parashat Balak. The Rabbi closed with the idea, first written by the **Shelah HaKadosh** about 400 years ago, that **Shavuot is a Yom HaDin for our Torah**. Just as Rosh Hashanah is about our vision and aspirations for the coming year, not only what we have done, so on Shavuot we are judged on our commitment to Torah, and over the next 48 hours

we position ourselves and set our ambitions with regard to HaKadosh Baruch Hu. Chag Sameach.

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